The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AP

America's economy added 130,000 jobs in January, almost double the number that analysts had been expecting, indicating that the labour market might have picked up after months of apparent stagnation. The unemployment rate also fell to 4.3%, a slight dip from the previous month. The figures may put off the Federal Reserve from lowering interest rates as fast as Donald Trump would like.

America's aviation regulator closed and then quickly reopened the skies over **El Paso** airport in Texas. The FAA said the ban was for "special security reasons"; the Trump administration claimed that **drones** belonging to Mexican drug cartels had entered American airspace. But surprised local officials and a Democratic congresswoman for El Paso questioned this explanation. Other sources reportedly said the closure was for a test of anti-drone technology.

A shooter killed at least nine people at a school and nearby residence in the Canadian province of **British Columbia**, before reportedly turning the weapon on themself. Authorities said that at least 25 other people were injured during the attack in Tumbler

Ridge. Police described the attacker as female. Further information, including a motive, has yet to be confirmed.

In a speech to mark the 47th anniversary of the Islamic revolution, **Iran's** president said the country is ready to have its nuclear programme inspected, and reiterated that it was not building an atomic weapon. His address came ahead of a meeting between Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, and **Donald Trump**. The two leaders will discuss possible military action against Iran.

Heineken said it would cut up to 6,000 jobs—roughly 7% of its global workforce—to reduce costs as demand for beer continues to go flat in Europe and America. The Dutch brewer saw a 1.2% drop in beer sales in 2025 compared with the year before. Its share price rose by 4% in early trading on the announcement.

Mistral AI pledged to spend €1.2bn ($1.4bn) building data centres in Sweden in partnership with EcoDataCentre, a Swedish data-centre operator. The French startup says it wants to boost AI capabilities in Europe and reduce the continent's dependence on American technology. Valued at almost €12bn, the firm remains considerably smaller than its American and Chinese rivals.

Switzerland will hold a referendum in June on capping its 9.1m population at 10m. The proposal, which is supported by the right-wing Swiss People's Party, gained the 100,000 signatures required to put it to a national vote. Proponents of the measure want to limit the number of immigrants and asylum-seekers; the population has grown faster in recent years than in most neighbouring countries.

Figure of the day: 90%, the share of informal jobs in India. Read the full story.

Photograph: Alamy

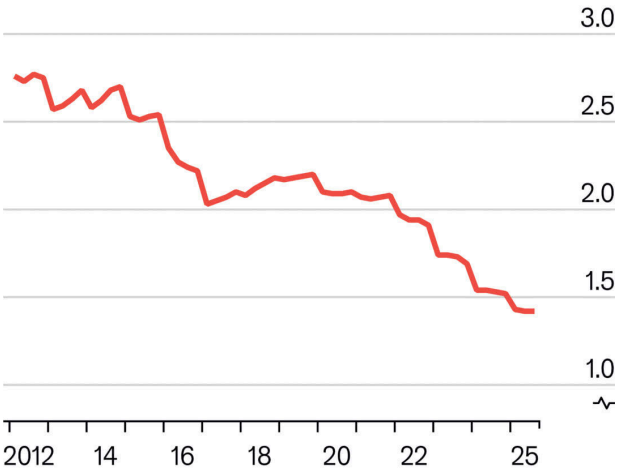
China’s reluctance to cut interest rates

Next month China’s government will reveal its inflation target for this year (probably 2%). It will almost certainly undershoot it, as it did last year. Figures released on Wednesday showed that consumer prices rose by only 0.2% in January, compared with a year earlier, despite a 77% rise in the cost of gold jewellery. The inflation rate for 2025 as a whole was zero.

Weak inflation is a sign that the economy is underperforming. Why is China’s central bank not cutting interest rates in response? It did last month lower the cost of lending for specific purposes, such as health care, farming and the energy transition. But it fears that easing monetary policy more broadly would further squeeze the profits of China’s banks, which now enjoy very little “margin” between their borrowing costs and their lending rates. To keep the banks cosy, it is willing to keep the economy cool.

Margin fall

China, commercial banks, net interest margin, %



Source: Wind

Photograph: Reuters

Decoding the Donroe doctrine

The western hemisphere's military chiefs will gather on Wednesday in a hotel in Washington, DC to hear what America's new interpretation of the Monroe Doctrine has in store. Attendees include officers from nearly all countries in Latin America and the Caribbean. Countries that rule over territories in the region—such as Britain, Denmark, France and the Netherlands—will be represented, too. Excluded are Venezuela, whose leader was snatched by American forces last month; and Cuba, whose regime America is keen to topple next.

American combatant commanders regularly host big meetings of senior officers in the regions where they operate. What is unusual is for America's chairman of the joint chiefs of staff, now General Dan Caine, to summon foreign military chiefs to Washington.

Expect emollient words about "strong partnerships" and exhortations to fight narco gangs. But the message will be uncompromising: America dominates the region; squeeze foes; push out the likes of China and Russia.

Photograph: Getty Images

A hollow anniversary in Iran

Revolution Day is usually marked by state parades, fireworks and ideological bombast across Iran. On Wednesday Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader, will again be lauding the “glory” of the Islamic republic forged in 1979. But this year feels different. A month after the regime’s bloody suppression of protests, Iran remains in mourning. Just over a month ago, on January 8th, Mr Khamenei unleashed his snipers who killed thousands countrywide. That bloodshed is more prominent in the public memory than the revolution 47 years ago.

Tens of thousands have been jailed, including former officials advocating reform. According to regime opponents, the rate of executions is climbing. The currency is collapsing, deepening Iranians’ economic woes. The presence offshore of Donald Trump’s armada raises fears of war, even as Iranian negotiators are in Oman hoping to promote a negotiated settlement with America. Mr Khamenei now speaks by pre-recorded video, wary of assassination. While he focuses on the past revolution, most Iranians are fixed on the transition to come.

Photograph: Reuters

Bibi’s nerve-racking trip to Washington

What happens next in Iran will be largely down to America. Israel’s prime minister, Binyamin Netanyahu, will meet President Donald Trump on Wednesday to discuss his administration’s intentions towards the country. Mr Netanyahu worries about two possible outcomes: a limited nuclear deal and limited military action. The first might contain Iran’s nuclear programme without reducing its arsenal of ballistic missiles or constraining the regional militias that it controls. The second might provoke regional chaos, and missile strikes on Israel, without bringing down Iran’s clerical regime.

It’s the toppling of the theocracy that Mr Netanyahu probably wants. But Mr Trump wants to avoid the protracted conflict that might be needed to bring it about. That may explain his recent change of tack. Last month he urged Iranians to keep protesting, even as the regime was killing them, because “help is on its way”. He sent the *USS Abraham Lincoln*, an aircraft-carrier, to underscore the promise. On Friday, though, he hailed “very good talks” with Iran in Oman. That set alarm bells ringing in Jerusalem.

Photograph: AP

American jobs: tardy but tenacious

Five days late, but worth the wait: America's releases of labour statistics on Wednesday surpassed expectations. The economy added 130,000 non-farm jobs in January—far more than the forecast of 70,000, and far beyond the 50,000 recorded in December. (The figures were delayed by a brief partial government shutdown.)

America's labour market looked a little wobbly in the second half of 2025. The Bureau of Labour Statistics revised job gains in 2025 from 584,000 to 181,000. But the jobs market seems to have stabilised. The unemployment rate, now at 4.3%, is not much higher than last summer, and jobless claims have dipped to near post-pandemic lows.

That makes Donald Trump's crusade for interest-rate cuts from the Federal Reserve harder to justify. In response to the figures, American Treasury yields jumped. Lower rates might make sense as medicine for an ailing labour market, but not for an economy in fine fettle.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Cymru is the alternative name for which nation, part of the UK?

Tuesday: Which American prison was home to both Al Capone and Machine Gun Kelly?

The task of leadership is not to put greatness into humanity, but to elicit it, for the greatness is already there.

John Buchan